INSIDE THE B-17

Packed with bombs and fuel, the B-17 had limited space for its crew. The bombardier and navigator had to crouch to reach their seats in the nose of the plane, although once there they enjoyed a superb view. The pilot and co-pilot sat on the flight deck, with the flight engineer above and behind them. The radio operator's room, separated from the flight deck by the bomb bay, was the only place where a man could stand fully upright. The ball-turret gunner occupied a notoriously cramped seat under the fuselage and the tail gunner had to crawl into his remote position.



Top guns
The gun positions on the top of the B-17's fuselage were manned in combat by the radio operator and the flight engineer.

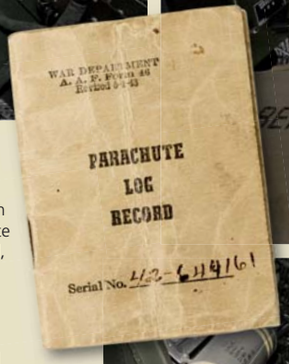


Manual controls
The controls of a B-17 were complex enough to require the collaboration of pilot and co-pilot if the aircraft was to be flown with any ease.





Norden bomb-sight
The Norden bomb-sight was installed behind the Plexiglass nose of the aircraft, in front of the bombardier's seat. Top-secret devices, the bomb-sights were removed from the aircraft between missions and kept under guard.



Parachute log
This log was used for recording each time the parachute was packed, used, and repaired.

Ball turret
The ball-turret gunner climbed into his cramped position after take-off. He had to sit with his knees drawn up to his chest and could not wear a parachute; he donned one rapidly in an emergency.





Bomb bay
The bomb bay, immediately behind the flight deck, had a walkway only some 20 cm (8 in) wide. The bombers typically carried some 2,700 kg (6,000 lb) of bombs, a mix of high explosive and incendiary munitions.

